

Kahila Lands

The Kahila

The Kahila (an Eibar word meaning 'the lost ones') are not a tribe, not a clan, and not subjects of any council. They are free folk, a term they use without irony or romanticism, simply as fact. For centuries, they have refused to adopt the theological authority of the Fatunik Dominion, the semi-feudal hierarchies of the western Rider provinces, the milder interpretations of the Fatunik beliefs, or even the amorphous nature worship of the southern regions. This refusal, especially respect to the Dominion, has cost them dearly in blood and land. Tet the Kahila identity persists, rooted not in governance structures but in shared resistance and memory.

Geographically, the Kahila claim three territories that could loosely be referred to a provinces. Kahilakol, also called Kahilabarbakol, in the east, is a densely forested region of some 17,000 square kilometers that remains their most militant stronghold. Kahilabequa, or Kahilabeq in the southern dialects, wraps around the western border of the Runes of Bye. It is roughly two-thirds the size of the easter Kahila territory and much more diverse geographically, with forest, mountains, plains and a river valley. Kahilabeq borders the Settan River and attracts traders as readily as rebels.

Kahilaqor is the lightly forested central corridor that once connected these provinces, but has been occupied by the Fatunik Dominion for two thirds of a century. The Kahila still call it theirs. The Fatuniks call it South Juukol. Neither claim has extinguished the other.

The Kahila conflicts involved decades of troubles that finally ended with official borders being declared and territories being occupied territories. The final Fatunik-Kahila War left scars deeper than any map can show. In Kahilaqor and Kahilabequa, forests were cut down

and villages burned. Survivors have buried their dead and rebuilt, but they did never forgot. The deep woods of Kahilakol swallowed refugees and rebels alike and is still home to those who would rather die free than live under Fatunik law. The long conflict ended in a terrible massacre, but the resistance never died.

Their origins go back to the years not long after the arrival of the great migration, when humu dissatisfied with Fatunik law broke away from Ingar. Nowadays, in a broad cultural sense, the Kahila resemble the peoples of the neighboring Outer Lands, Mobalbesq and the Runes of Bye, more so than their northern Fatunik neighbors. They organize around festivals rather than councils. They share resources through informal networks rather than guilds. And they resolve disputes through communal discussion rather than juridical pronouncement. In other ways, they more closely resemble the Ny Landers, further down the east coast of the Saskan Lands, in that their settlements tend to be fluid, adaptive, and often temporary. Permanent structures feel like targets. Trees and tunnels offer better sanctuary.

Despite their reputation for militancy, especially for those in the deep forest, where Kahilakol means 'Kahila militia' as much as it does 'the eastern Kahila lands' or 'the Kahila forest', many Kahila are in fact traders, artisans, hunters and farmers. Inside the forest communities, distinctions between rebel and merchant is often meaningless. The same person who smuggles weapons to Kahilakol resistance fighters might also broker deals in Settarune for timber and river-caught fish in Brokily's markets. The romperi, which are simply criminal bands by both Fatunik and Rider definitions, are by Kahila reckoning more like mutual aid networks. They operate openly and within traditional strictures inside the Kahila territories, where their presence neither condemned nor celebrated but simply accepted as part of the centuries-old social fabric.

The Kahila explicitly do not worship Fatune in any manner, though some still observe old solar customs stripped of any theological content. They do not swear fealty to council or lords or high tables or prophets or even chiefs, nor do they seek protection from Rider Arms

or Nylander mercenaries. They do not offer learned well-researched petitions the Elders of Juuj. What they do is endure, adapt, and remember. Around countless campfires and tree-tops and gatherings, they tell stories of massacres and victories and escapes and origins, all with equal detail and often with a good bit of humor. They teach their children the names of both the dead and the living, the dead to remember and living to find paths through the forest that no map will ever record.

In recent turns, since the troubles have ended and something like peace has come to the borders of their lands, some Kahila factions have begun a cautious engagement with the broader Saskan communities, especially in the neighboring Outer Land provinces. Trade agreements. Limited observation of Runik legal frameworks through the Night Hall. Tentative alliances with some Mobalbesq communes. Many Kahila, especially the most militant bands, view such engagement as capitulation, as forgetting. The tension between resistance and integration runs through every Kahila gathering, percolates up into every late-night debate in Brokily's inns, and informs every decision about whether to send supplies to the militants in Kahilakol or invest in the new road leading to the land of the Mobali communes.

The Kahila are not unified by government, theology, blood or religion. They are unified by what they have refused and what they have survived.

Kahilakol

On its flanks, facing Fatunik provinces to the east, north and west, and facing Mobalbesq to the south, the Kahilabarbakol protects its boundaries with a barricade eight meters high of fallen trees.

Travelers going past Ríkila on the Ring Road have a good view of the stockade from the road. An uneven rampart of timber rises and falls like frozen waves. Fresh windfall lies atop weathered trunks centuries

old, the whole mass stretching north and south beyond sight. Whether this barricade formed naturally or through deliberate engineering remains unclear. People must work on it at some point. No one is ever seen maintaining it, yet it grows. No one guards it, yet it persists.

In the Kahilakol, the forest seems to speak its own language of refusal, and the message is unambiguous.

Six or seven kilometers from the broken walls of Ríkila, a massive circular door marks the only sanctioned entrance into the forest from its eastern boundary. Symbols older than the Fatunik Dominion are carved into its face. Those who pass through pay a toll. Not to any government, but to the keepers who live in the trees and know every hidden trail beyond.

Kahilakol, called Kahilabarbakol in the old more complex dialect of Eibar still spoken within, is the densest forest in Saskantanon. The canopy closes overhead like interlaced fingers. Beneath it, the Kahila have built a civilization of burrows, rope bridges, platforms lashed to ancient trunks, and villages that can be dismantled and relocated in a single night, or even in a matter of hours. They move through this labyrinth silently as the rain.

The Fatunik Tagabant gave up trying to control the deep Kahila forest many, many generations ago. Their expeditions returned depleted, disoriented, or not at all. During the time of the Elders of Juuj, the Dominion's strategy shifted to containment. Accommodate the Moballeq Clan to the south of the forest; encourage them draw the Kahila in their direction and away from the Dominion's borders. Fortify the borders with Pavanarune, Rutonijal and Juukol. Isolate the Kahilakol from outside support by making travel through the corridor difficult. This strategy failed on all fronts.

Mikel Moballeq and his descendants were happy to trade with the Kahila, but had no interest in getting involved in their internal affairs. Instead, the Kahilakol used their goodwill with the Moballeq lords to secure passage through the Runes of Bye in order to have an alternative route connecting Kahilabequa with the eastern forest-

dwellers. Those routes through Mobalbesq and Pavanarune remain well-traveled to this day, profitable to all parties, and largely peaceful. Along the borders with the Dominion province, and in the Kahilaqor, Kahila raiders redoubled their efforts, striking Tagabant camps and Fatunik villages alike in lightning raids before escaping back into the woods.

Kahilakol has no towns. Large villages are rare and never permanent. The population lives dispersed and mobile, experts at appearing when needed and vanishing when threatened. The very idea of census-taking and taxation is absurd. The region exists in permanent defiance of administrative logic.

What Kahilakol has always had and still has, even after the devastation wrought by Tonedor Rumpet, is rebels. Every variety of rebels. The romperi operate here in bands ranging from sophisticated smuggling operations to straightforward banditry. The bitamin, professional and highly-skilled mercenaries, maintain cells throughout the forest. Each group has specialty: assassins, paramilitaries, ideological commandos, spies. Some bitamin groups focus on harassing Fatunik forces in the occupied corridor. Others are biding their time, looking for broader alliances, and thus are training sint fighters from the Untamed. Some of the romperi have shifted toward quasi-legitimate trade networks, working especially with innkeepers and merchants in Ríkila and beyond. And for every serious and well-organized romperi or bitamin outfit, there are dozens of wannabe groups, youngsters playing at war, at being gangsters or angels of vengeance or valiant heroes or defenders of the forest.

All of these organizations, even the less serious ones, are respected among the Kahila, especially in the eastern forest despite their criminality, and sometimes their silliness, because of what their existence represents: ungovernable life, refusal of imposed order, survival through solidarity and skill, the refusal to surrender. The Tagabant call them terrorists. The Riders call them criminals. The scholars of the Byenung beg them to take the long view. The Kahila simply call them neighbors and friends.

The persistence of Kahilakol, its proximity to the ancient Authority at Juuj, its shelter for refugees and radicals, its sheer defiance, was the main reason the Dominion established its New Fatunik Authority at Beshquahoek. The old guard at Juuj could not subdue the forest. The Beshquo Reforms represented an admission of that failure, a recalibration of power that acknowledged what could not be conquered needed to be very forcefully contained before it could ever be negotiated with.

Travel through Kahilakol remains dangerous for anyone bearing Tagabant or even basic Fatunik sigils. Those passing through this region stick to the Ring Road that skirts the forest's northern and western rim, even though the direct way to Selaron would like straight through the forest. Inside, the trails are known only to those who live there and are safe only for those granted passage. Even then, the forest keeps its secrets. Paths shift. Landmarks you thought you remembered from a previous journey have vanished. Guides appear and disappear and new ones appear without explanation.

The folk of the Kahilakol see themselves as the truest inheritors of the old ways. They are the ones who never bowed to Fatune, never compromised, and never signed treaties that they knew would be broken. They look at their cousins in Kahilabequa with complicated feelings. They respect those who endured the greatest horrors, get frustrated with those who speak of accommodation, and remain suspicious of those who build bridges instead of barricades, even though that kind of integration with Saskan folks outside of the great wall of fallen trees is probably more advanced, in some ways, in the east, at Ríkila, than in the west, at Brokily.

On nights when traders from Brokily arrive with news of kin in the west and supplies, when scouts bring word of from Ríkila of the latest accomplishments of Kirill Geckster, when someone plays a flute from a platform high in the canopy and the sound carries for kilometers through the quiet dark... On those nights, the distinction between resistance and survival dissolves into the starlight. What remains is simply a people who live in the trees, who remember what was taken

from them, and who have made a home in the last place their enemies can reach.

Kahilabequa

Kahilabequa remembers the fires.

The province is smaller than Kahilakol but open to the sky and its forests younger. Many of the newer trees have grown from ash. The villages were burned during the Fatunik War. Not in battle, but methodically, as policy. Fatunik forces moved through the region with torches and orders. What could not be controlled would be erased. The massacres that followed are recorded in Kahila oral tradition with the same precision other cultures reserve for sacred texts. Names, dates, locations. The dead are not abstractions here.

The resistance never died, but it learned to whisper, especially among the Kahilabeq.

Kahilabequa is less openly defiant than its eastern sibling. The culture has settled into patterns somewhat similar to the southern Settan provinces: pastoral rhythms, river trade, seasonal markets, rebuilt villages that look almost peaceful if you don't know what stood there before. The province borders the Settan River and sits between Settarune, the Runes of Bye and Tablunque, not all that far from Beshquahoek. In the current times it attracts entrepreneurs more readily than paramilitaries. Merchants from Barból and Byenung come here to trade. The new bridge at Brokily town carries goods and travelers in both directions across the river.

But peaceful is not the same as pacified.

Political life in Kahilabequa revolves around an unresolved question: what now? Some support the militants in Kahilakol. They send supplies and offer sanctuary to the bitamin groups who strike at

Fatunik positions in the occupied corridor. Others are taking a long hard look at the Night Hall's legalistic approach to autonomy: negotiations, documentation, treaties that might actually be observed. Still others study the Mobali communes and wonder if a federated cultural identity, without direct confrontation and with a bit less of the spirit of pure libertarian anarchy that the Kahila are so fond of, might be the best path forward. These debates happen in Brokily's guild halls, in taverns along the Settan, in farmhouses after the children sleep, in places where neither Tagabant spies nor Kahilakol militants are likely to overhear them.

Conversations about reunification with Kahilakol and ending the occupation of Kahilaqor are conducted carefully. The province sits just south of the Fatunik Dominion's most heavily fortified heartland. The border with Tablunque province, the undisputed center of Fatunik power in the era of Tonedor Rumpet, is heavily guarded on both sides. Outposts line the frontier. Patrols are frequent. Spies are everywhere, or so everyone assumes, which has much the same effect.

The occupied corridor haunts every discussion. Kahilaqor connects the two Kahila province, runs close to Beshquahoek, the Dominion's capital but also, as some folks seem to forget, has a long twisting border with the Runes of Bye to the south. The bloodiest battles of the Fatunik onslaught were fought in the corridor. The Tagabant invaders ultimately seized the entire territory and then established their new seat of power nearby. It was a symbolic and strategic victory that cut the Kahila lands in half, then stabbed it in the heart. The Noonday Scribes renamed the corridor South Juukol now and announced that it has been annexed to Juukol province. Nevertheless, very few Fatunik hum have been convinced to relocate there. The Kahila call it occupied and are making plan for that designation to change.

At the northern edges of Kahilabequa, on the frontier with Tablunque, stands the Kahila fortress of Iyag'holt. It was built in response to the permanent Fatunik military camps established along border of Kahilabeq and in the occupied corridor. The Kahilabeq consider those Tagabant encampments an obscene provocation, boots on the wound.

Iyag'holt is the only formal fortified military installation in Kahila lands. It watches the border and does not attack, but it does not sleep either, and it stares directly, albeit across some 100 kilometers, directly at Beshqauhoek.

The fortress is supported by a bitamin network who monitor Tagabant movements, manage flows of weapons and ammunition to Kahilakol and to the fortress, and provide logistical support for occasional armed actions in the occupied corridor. These operations are covert enough to maintain deniability and overt enough to remind the New Authority that the war may have ended, but despite any agreements made by the western tribes, the Kahila have not surrendered and never will.

Although there is the fortification of Iyag'holt, which stands defiantly like big middle finger gesturing permanently towards Beshqauhoek and there are all sort of underground networks, Kahilabequa still has no centralized government. Like Kahilakol and the Ny Lands and Arq, its people are just not comfortable with administrative hierarchies. To be sure, Brokily, the only settled town in either Kahila province, exerts considerable influence through its merchant guilds. They function like a leading council without ever claiming that title. But authority remains diffuse. Decisions emerge from discussion rather than decree. The anti-authoritarian spirit that defines Kahila culture permeates everything, even in Kahilabequa.

This creates tensions. Younger Kahilabeq, who of course did not live through the "final" war, sometimes chafe at the caution of their elders. They want action, not whispered debate. They look east to the militants of Kahilakol with envy, and west to the Riders with neither contempt nor fear but with something like longing. What if we had weapons like that?... The older generation, who buried countless children and rebuilt villages from charcoal, counsel patience. They remember what open rebellion costs. They wonder if another war would leave any Kahila alive to remember.

Between these extremes lies most of the western Kahila population: farmers who pay no taxes but share harvests with neighbors, traders

who move goods through ancient hidden networks the Watchers and the Meyajo cannot map, artisans whose work never appears in official records, and families who teach their children the names of the dead and of the living so that the routes through the forests will never be lost.

The Settan River runs through all of this too, both literally and metaphorically. It is the current connecting Kahilabequa to a much broader networks of trade and communication. Brokily sits on its northern bank, the bridge spanning the mother of waters like an offered hand. Boats carry grain, timber, and news in both directions. The river traffic is legal, documented. Fees are collected and paid -- the Settan version of Riverwaq, which includes sentient river dolphins, among others. And beneath flow runs another current: messages, money, materials moving between those who remember the fire, those who refuse to let them burn again, and those who envision a whole different kind of future not only for the Kahila, but for all the Saskan folk.

Kahilabequa does not wave banners or shout slogans. It rebuilds quietly. It trades carefully. It remembers everything. When Fatunik Watchers visit and ask about loyalty to the New Authority, about compliance with the treaty that ended the war, about agreement with the Beshquo Reforms, the answers are polite, vague, and utterly uninformative. The Fatuniks may have won a military victory sixty-eight years ago, but they have never won over a single Kahila heart or soul.

The forests are regrowing. Many villages have been rebuilt. Children play in fields that were once battlefields, and their parents let them play there, dancing on the bones, because what else can you do? But at night, when the Settan whispers against its banks and the smoke from the watch-fires of Iyag'holt rise into the dark, everyone knows: the occupation continues, the corridor remains severed, and the question is not if things will change but when, and how, and at what cost.

Occupied Kahilaqor

There is a road through Kahilaqor that Kahila elders remember as a children's path. It ran between Kahilakol and Kahilabequa through meadows and light forest, connecting families, festivals, seasonal gatherings. Children traveled it with their grandparents to visit cousins in the other province. Traders used it to move goods. Lovers used it to meet up. It was not the only route between the provinces. It was the most loved of all the Kahila paths: gentle terrain, good water, places to rest, the place in-between all the other places.

The Tagabant commanders now refer to that road as a military supply route. They patrol it. Checkpoints divide it into segments. The meadows have been cleared far back from the roadside to provide better sight lines for sentries. All the old rest stops are gone. The magnificent trees that once offered shade to lovers are stumps.

Kahilaqor, the corridor, the wound. Over sixty turns under occupation, though the Kahila have never used that number as if it means the suffering is old. Ten turns, forty, sixty. It is nothing against the memory of connection, of wholeness, of being able to walk between your own lands, for century after century, without asking anyone for permission.

The territory is not large, pretty much just a strip of land linking east and west, connecting Kahilakol's forests to Kahilabequa's eclectic countryside. But its size is not what makes it precious. It is the only land route between the two provinces that does not require passage through non-Kahila territory. Without it, the Kahila lands exist as two islands, close enough to see each other's smoke but unable to touch except through circuitous routes that require the grudging hospitality of intermediaries.

The Fatunik Dominion took all of the Kahilaqor in the final, brutal phase of the Fatunik-Kahila war. They annexed it to Juukol province and renamed it South Juukol, though the Elders of Juuj themselves have never formally recognized that proclamation of the Noonday

Scribes. The Dominion established its New Authority at Beshquahoek, a short two days ride from the Kahila lands. It was a statement in stone and steel and fire that this land would never be returned, that the severance was permanent, that the Kahila lands would remain divided or they would cease to exist.

The bloodiest battles in Kahila history were fought for this ground. Villages that stood here for generations were razed. Not just a few. All of them. Fields were salted. The less heavily forested terrain that had made Kahilaqor ideal for travel and habitation made it impossible to defend for long with traditional Kahila tactics against a massive infantry assault. There was nowhere to hide, nowhere to retreat. Those who fought here died in open ground, visible, counted. Thousands of their bones still fertilize the corridor's blood-soaked ground.

The Tagabant built their biggest military camps at the corridor's western end, in Tablunque province, during the war's final years. For the Kahila, the enormous camps represented something worse than military occupation. They were the visible machinery of dismemberment, the mechanism ensuring that what had been cut would stay severed. When the High Council of Beshquahoek refused to dismantle the camps after the war's official end, Kahilabequa started to construct Iyag'holt on their side of the border. Not to attack. To witness. To remember. To refuse.

A Kahila living in eastern Kahilakol and wanting to visit relatives or team mates in western Kahilabequa now faces several options. They can attempt the corridor crossing. It will require bribes, interrogations, searches, and the humiliation of asking permission to walk roads their grandparents traveled freely. Documentation is required. Purpose of travel must be justified. Cargo is inspected, often confiscated. Many are turned back without explanation. Some are detained.

Or they can travel the long alternative routes through the Outer Lands. East through Mobalbesq and the Runes Bye. It can take weeks instead of days. Expensive. Dependent on the goodwill of others. Safe, relatively, but the safety is bought with distance, time, and the constant awareness that this journey should not be necessary. And it

requires passing through territories where Kahila presence is tolerated, but not exactly welcomed. Every traveler is a guest, grateful for passage but aware the welcome could be withdrawn. And staying at a Runik Inn for the night inevitably involves getting drawn into a long drawn-out discussion on the relative merits of materials to use when constructing a water paddle, or some other equally pressing matter so dear to the hearts of the Runik folk.

The New Fatunik Authority asserts that Kahilaqor is integrated, pacified, and productive, that Fatunik settlers are peacefully farming there now. That roads are well maintained and trade flows. The Authority makes these assertions, mostly false, to provide evidence of the progress, development, and civilization that comes with the light of Fatune. They do not mention that the few Fatunik farms in the region sit on land taken from folk who were killed or expelled, and they have to be guarded day and night. They don't mention that the trade flows one direction, out to the Tagabant camps. They do not mention that the roads mainly serve military logistics and only very secondarily civilian travel.

There are still Kahila in Kahilaqor. Some have crept back in, especially near the borders with Kahilakol, Kahilabeq and the Runes of Bye. They live under occupation with the careful silence of people who have learned which words draw attention. They work land that had never been considered to be "owned" by anyone for untold generations, and now pay "rent" to self-declared Fatunik landlords, every one of whom is a Tagabant officer of some kind. They teach their broodkins how to code-switch into the Fatunik dialect of Eibar when talking to the foreigners, and keep their own "archaic" tongue for home and fields. They do not smile at any Fatunik. And if at all possible, they do not speak to them either.

SOME live in Kahilaqor because they were pushed there. Mostly prisoners and refugees from the onslaught who had fallen into the hands of local officials in Juukol, then resettled into border villages where they could be watched. These villages have mixed populations of resettled Kahila and Fatunik immigrants who are mostly former

soldiers granted land. The intention is integration, assimilation, and the gradual erasure of distinction. Certain folks in Juukol and elsewhere believe this is good work. The reality is a parallel existence. Groups that share geography but nothing else, living beside each other like oil and water forced into the same container.

Kahila living in the corridor always try to maintain contact with relatives in the un occupied provinces. They pass messages. They host visitors when travel is possible. They send their children to Kahilakol or Kahilabequa during summers or harvest times, maintaining connections however they can. A very few have made accommodations: bred with Fatuniks, converted to worship of Fatune, learned to say "South Juukol" without sounding like they are spitting. Survival takes many forms. But judgment is typically harsh in such cases. Stripped animal carcasses nailed to their doorways. Salt dumped into their vegetable patches. Banishment from traditional festivals.

Bitamin groups from Kahilakol conduct operations in the corridor. Small actions, usually. A supply depot burned. Communications disrupted. A remote Tagabant patrol ambushed and robbed, but not killed. Not enough to provoke full military response. Just enough to ensure the occupation never becomes comfortable. The Tagabant calls this residual warfare. The Kahila call it fair play.

Children born in Kahilaqor after the war know the corridor only as contested, occupied ground. They have never walked freely between the provinces. They have never experienced the Kahila lands as whole. When elders speak of the time before, these children listen politely and understand intellectually, but they cannot feel it. The wound is their normal. The severance is their inheritance.

At night, from very high trees in Kahilakol, you can see lights in villages in the occupied corridor. On still nights, if the wind is right, sound carries. Voices, music, the ordinary sounds of life. People stand at the top of those high points, looking west toward the lights of the villages, thinking about the road that used to run through Kahilaqor, the meadows that used to bloom, the children who used to travel it

singing.

The Kahila have never accepted the occupation. Acceptance would mean agreeing that their land could be legitimately taken, that the occupation is normal, that the names used by the High Council in Beshquahoek are real names. So they continue to call it Kahilaqor, to speak of the corridor as occupied rather than annexed, to teach their children that the Kahila lands are three provinces, not two, that the only proper way to speak Eibar is the old way, and that what was severed will one day be made whole.

Whether they believe this, after two generations, is harder to say. Hope and defiance are not the same thing. You can refuse to accept a reality without believing you will change it. You can insist on the truth of the past without confidence in the future. The Kahila do this. They have learned to carry the contradiction without resolving it. The corridor is ours, the corridor is lost, the corridor will be returned, the corridor may never be returned. All of the above, all at once.

Even if the scars are hard now, the pain of the wound does not heal. But neither does it kill. It remains, painful, always present, the truth that defines everything that grows around it.

Brokily

The first thing travelers notice about the town of Brokily is that it doesn't follow straight lines.

The town grew organically over centuries, following the logic of river bend and forest edge rather than any surveyor's grid. Streets wind and branch like tributary streams. Alleys dead-end into courtyards or suddenly open onto the riverside. Buildings lean companionably against their neighbors at angles that suggest conversation. The effect is charming if you're visiting, maddening if you're trying to find an address, and strategically useful if you need to disappear quickly.

The second thing travelers notice is that Brokily survived.

Signs of the Fatunik war are everywhere. Old burn scars on timber frames patched with newer wood, empty lots where buildings once stood, foundations that now support gardens instead of houses. The town was rebuilt. The Night Hall helped, particularly the Runes of Bye, who sent materials and expertise and asked for nothing in return except a long conversation. The new construction mingles with older structures that somehow weathered the fires, creating a visual patchwork that tells the town's history in wood and stone.

Brokily sits just north of the Settan River, at the southern tip of Kahilabequa. The location made it valuable long before the massacres. It is the only sizable municipality between Barból and Byenung astride the river, and that makes it essential, especially now. Goods flow through Brokily from both east and west. Even a limited amount of trade between the Settan Lands and the central parts of the Fatunik Dominion passes through here. The new bridge, completed two decades ago, connects directly to the Ring Road 120 kilometers south and it has made Brokily wealthy in ways that still feel surprising to those who remember the devastation.

The bridge itself is beautiful. A low arch of pale stone seems to float above the water. Kahila engineers designed it with Runik consultation, blending techniques in ways that created something neither culture would have built alone. It serves as practical proof that the Kahila can build, not just resist. They can create infrastructure that benefits others, not just defend territory. The bridge says we are not merely victims or rebels. We are creators.

The town's architecture reflects its history and values. Timber-frame construction dominates. Heavy wooden beams are filled with wattle and daub or clay, materials drawn from the surrounding forests and river banks. Thatched roofs slope at comfortable angles, their reeds replaced each year in a communal effort that doubles as social event. What makes Brokily distinct are the carvings.

Every building bears decoration. Geometric patterns that echo Kahila

forest symbolism, stylized animals, narrative scenes from folk tales, abstract designs whose meanings are debated in taverns. The carvings are not mere ornament. They identify the builder, commemorate events, signal political affiliations, or simply demonstrate that beauty matters even in a town that has been burned. The carvers are respected artisans. Their work transforms functional structures into statements.

The central market square anchors Brokily's daily life. It occupies ground that was once three separate buildings, destroyed in the wars and never rebuilt. Instead, the Kahila of Brokilly paved the space with river stones and created an open plaza. Market stalls appear each morning. Canvas tents and wooden tables displaying everything from salted fish to ornamental metalwork. The air fills with competing smells: baking bread, curing leather, spices from Mobalbesq, the green scent of fresh-cut herbs. Voices layer in multiple languages: the ancient tones of Kahila-inflected Eibar predominates, but you hear plenty of Settarune Sogomsh, Runik dialects of Eibar, Arql and Sogomsh, coastal trade pidgins, and even occasional idioms from the north and the west.

The square serves more than commercial purposes. It's where notices are posted, disputes mediated, news shared, and informal assemblies convened. The merchant guilds, such as they are, meet in halls near the square. But the real decisions, the ones that shape Kahila response to external pressures, often begin with conversations between traders at day's end, sitting on upturned crates with mugs of warm s'lah, discussing what they've heard from travelers and what it might mean.

Brokily has no mayor, no town council, no formal government. The Kahila folk have never operated like that. The largest merchant associations function something like a leading council without ever claiming that authority explicitly. They coordinate bridge maintenance, organize the town watch, negotiate with the Rider Arms about permitted presence, and manage relationships with Byenung, with the Runes and with the Fatunik Watchers. Their power is consultative, not coercive. They suggest, coordinate, facilitate. They

do not command.

This creates an administrative flexibility that baffles many outside observers. When Fatunik officials visit expecting to meet with whoever is in charge, they find themselves passed between from one representative to next, each of whom has expertise in some narrow domain but none of whom can speak for Brokily as a whole. The meetings accomplish little. This is no accident.

The Rider Arms maintain a small barracks on the northern edge of town that is associated with an Inn run by the Riders Union. Various informal agreements keep trade flowing and tensions manageable between Kahilabeq as whole and Brokily in particular, on the one hand, and the faraway Cann of Bordered on the other. The Rider Inn is solid, professional, deliberately unremarkable. Perhaps forty Riders rotate through it during the four seasons, enough to patrol roads and provide security for caravans going in and out of Brokily, but not enough to patrol or police the town. The relationship between the Riders and the Kahila folk of Brokily is cordial, wary, and pragmatic. The Riders understand they are guests. The Kahila understand the Riders might turn out to be very useful guests if large-scale hostilities ever erupt again.

People seldom talk about it. It happened 300 turns back, when the Elders still held the Authority. But everybody knows that, unlike the onslaught that laid low the Kahila lands, when nobody came to their aid, the attempted Fatunik assault on Eelan was stopped when the Riders threatened to intervene.

Tagabant forces are prohibited from entering Brokily town. This prohibition, negotiated after the war, is one of the few Fatunik concessions the Kahila successfully defended. The purpose of the Tagabant is to enforce Fatunik law and Fatunik theology. The Kahila refuse to admit this has any purpose in their lands. Tagabant presence would make Brokily occupied territory. So they patrol the northern approaches to the town, watch the roads, and occasionally arrest Kahila travelers outside the town's boundaries. All of which is regularly protested. No Kahilabeq wants to see the sigil of the Khālo

Bridge waving on a banner inside their lands, but they have been unable to prevent the Fatunik soldiers from encroaching into the countryside. But they do not cross the threshold into Brokily.

The Kahila provide their own informal town watch. Volunteers rotate through the duty, wearing no uniforms and carrying no special kit, but recognized by everyone. They handle disputes, intervene in fights, escort drunks home, and keep their eyes on both the northern gate and the Rider Inn without making it obvious. In the rare cases where serious violence occurs or an actual crime needs investigating, the merchants ask the elders to convene a hearing. The process is neither quick nor formal, but it generally reaches conclusions that the community accepts.

What the town watch does not discuss publicly is their other function, the one every Kahilabeq in Brokily knows about and many of them participate in, but nobody talks about. Managing the covert support Brokily provides to bitamin units operating in the corridor is the wind that whispers on every breath. Supplies move through the town in ways that don't appear in any ledger. Safe houses exist in rooms behind rooms, cellars beneath cellars. Messages travel through channels that look like ordinary commerce and sound like ordinary songs. The weapons that arrive at bitamin depots in Kahilakol often pass through Brokily first, though no one could prove this because no one keeps records and everyone knows when to look away.

Brokily's streets reveal the town's character in small details. Residences cluster along winding lanes, their timber frames weathered silver-gray, small gardens visible through gates. Some houses feature interior courtyards. These private spaces hide behind street-facing walls, often with fruit trees and benches where small groups gather in the evening. These courtyards represent a shift toward permanence that still feels new to many. The Kahila historically avoided fixed settlements. Brokily was the exception, but the town had a temporary feel to it. Now there are courtyards, suggesting people plan to stay put.

Their inns are a particular points of pride. Brokily hosts travelers from

across the Saskan Lands, and its innkeepers belong to the Free Hostelries Cooperative organized by the Riders Union, the same collective that owns and manages the Rider Inns. But this is the eastern, more autonomous branch, not the branch managed directly from Bordered. It maintains relationships with Rider unions without submitting to their oversight. The Brokily inns offer clean beds, decent food, and information networks that rival the vaunted Rider intelligence service. An innkeeper in Brokily knows who's traveling where, who's avoiding whom, what goods are scarce, and what rumors are circulating before non-Kahila merchants hear similar whispers. And, of course, they participate in the whispers too.

The Inn of the Full Moons in Ríkila has the spirit of a Brokily Inn. Run by Kirill Geckter and serving as headquarters for the powerful romperi outfit called the Annaki Intimi, the Full Moons represents the blurred line between legitimate business and romperi operations that characterizes much of Kahila economic life. That it is located inside a Fatunik town makes Kirill Geckter a folk hero throughout the Kahila lands and beyond. Nearly every Inn in Brokily boasts multiple carvings extolling the antics of the famous "Master of the Manifold Ways". Traders who have frequented Brokily often choose to make a journey to Ríkila specifically to visit the Full Moons, conduct business with Kirill, not only to access networks that official channels cannot provide, but for bragging rights when they return to Brokily.

A spiritual life in exists Brokily exists but it does not dominate daily life. There are, of course, no Fatunik temples of any kind. A few families maintain small shrines to entirely different solar deities, stripped of any Fatunik content and observed more as cultural practice than belief, usually tied to additional astronomical rituals. Some participate in Runik philosophical discussions, attracted to their legal frameworks and epistemological flexibility and that can sometimes feel like spiritual work. Most practice no formal rituals at all, finding community and meaning in work, team, resistance, traditional Kahila festivals and the collective memory of survival.

The riverside itself serves as a kind of secular sacred space. People

gather at day's end to watch the Settan's flow, skip stones, fish, or simply sit. Children play in the shallows during warm months. Boats dock at wooden piers that smell of tar and fish. The river provides food, transportation, defense, escape and continuity. Whatever happens on land, the river continues. The current precedes hum concerns and will outlast them.

On market days, when the square fills and voices rise and the smell of cooking food drifts through the streets, Brokily feels almost festive. You could forget, briefly, that this is a town rebuilt from ash, that the Kahilaqor remains occupied, that Tagabant patrol the countryside, that every family here lost ancestors and kin in the wars. Then you notice the empty lot where a tavern once stood, or the burn scar on a beam, or the way certain older people fall silent, a strange look of hope and longing on their faces, when a Rider Arms patrol passes, and you remember.

Brokily is the contradiction at the heart of Kahila life. It is peaceful but not pacified, thriving but not healed, integrated into regional trade networks but fundamentally ungoverned and ungovernable. It accommodates and even welcomes the Rider Arms while supporting the bitamin. It builds bridges while remembering what was destroyed. It is, depending on who you ask, either the future of the Kahila and a proof they can adapt and prosper without abandoning their values or it is a dangerous compromise, the first step toward assimilation and the gradual erasure of everything that makes them Kahila.

Both might be true. The town doesn't resolve the contradiction. It lives inside it, waking each morning to bake bread and carve wood and twist metal and move goods and honor the dead and praise the living and argue about what comes next. The debates continue in taverns and guild halls and around kitchen tables. No consensus emerges. None is expected.

The Settan keeps flowing. The bridge connects the banks. The town persists, built on questions that have no answers, carrying forward because stopping would mean accepting that the fires won.

The Romperi and the Bitamin

To understand the romperi ('breakers' in Old Eibar) and bitamin ('night warriors' in Old Eibar'), you must first understand that the Kahila do not draw the same line between criminal and law-abiding that operates elsewhere in the Saskan Lands. The distinction exists, but it's permeable, contextual, and often irrelevant. A person might spend spring planting crops, summer running contraband, autumn at a festival giving away everything they've earned, and winter training fighters in the deep forest. These are not separate identities. They are the rhythms of Kahila life.

The romperi are organized bands, some small, some extensive, focused primarily on moving goods and resources through networks that ignore official borders and regulations. The bitamin range from individual operatives to paramilitary cells, offering services from assassination to training to armed resistance. In both cases, the level of expertise and organization ranges from best-in-class to laughably inept.

The Fatunik Authority denounce them as thieves and murderers. The Rider Arms see them as problems requiring containment. The Kahila call them by name, because most everyone knows someone in a romperi band or has kin who at least trained with a bitamin unit.

What outsiders miss is that these organizations exist because they serve functions that formal governance would provide elsewhere. They move goods where trade restrictions would prevent it and in a society where a 'career' called 'merchant' doesn't exist outside of Brokily town. They protect communities where no policing force is going to come. They enforce agreements where no courts have jurisdiction because there are no courts. They train people in skills that through the centuries have saved many lives. They keep

communication channels open between the Kahila provinces. The words themselves are amorphous. Is someone a 'romperi' if they help to divert some food shipments to villages in the occupied corridor? Does pulling the pegs from the wheels of a Tagabant cart while they're looking the other way require bitamin training?

But there is more to it than this. And here is what confuses those who study the Kahila from a distance. The romperi and bitamin are integrated into the cultural fabric that actually holds the Kahila together. The festivals, the ritual gift-giving, the seasonal gatherings where dispersed and often hidden communities come together to be visible, and to see to that all Kahila are abundant and whole.

The Kahila have no government. Instead the Kahila have hundreds of festivals held by various collections of bands throughout the year, timed to harvests, solstices, successful raids, or simply because enough people feel the need to celebrate. These festivals are where the Kahila become most themselves. Bands that normally operate in isolation converge on forest clearings or riverbanks. Platforms are built, fires lit, food prepared in quantities that seem reckless until you understand the purpose.

A potlatch tradition has structured such gatherings since the Fatunik scribes of Ingar first started calling the forest heretics Kahila almost two thousand turns back. Groups compete to give away more than they received, to demonstrate abundance through generosity rather than accumulation. A successful romperi band arrives with crates of goods acquired through questionable means and distributes them freely. It is not charity, rather a demonstration of prowess and solidarity. A bitamin cell might gift weapons they've smuggled, a special training session, or simply stories of successful operations that everyone present will remember and retell.

The giving creates obligation and connection. A family that receives gifts at one gathering knows they must reciprocate at the next, not to the same people necessarily, but into the communal flow. Wealth that pools becomes a source of shame unless it's released back into circulation. Hoarding marks you as outside Kahila values more surely

than any crime the Fatuniks might name.

These festivals also reveal the diversity that defines Kahila culture. While predominantly huum, the Kahila have long welcomed sints into their communities. In the forests and at the gatherings, you see rabbit-sints moving through the canopy with a grace that inspires awe, gecko-sints like Kirill Geckter whose small size and different needs find accommodation rather than mockery, bear-sints whose strength is celebrated in heroic ballads, and monkey-sints whose perspective from above has saved countless lives.

The Kahila became a haven by necessity and by choice. For centuries, they have absorbed refugees and wanderers. Those who found Fatunik theology suffocating, Runik intellectualism sterile, Rider hierarchy degrading, or the long days of pastoral monotony in Settarune and Baranuk unbearably boring. Deserters from various armies, fugitives from various laws, heretics from various orthodoxies, they all end up in the forest at one time or another. And if you can reach the forest and you abide by the Kahila ways, you can stay.

This creates a culture that is at the same time both intensely loyal and remarkably tolerant. The shared experience of rejection by mainstream Saskan societies, the common commitment to living free of any imposed authority, the practical necessity of cooperation for survival... these bonds override differences that would fracture communities elsewhere. A former Tagabant who has genuinely rejected Fatunik ideology lives beside an exuberant fox-sint who would be arrested on sight in Dominion territory. They work together, share resources, and raise the next generation who consider both of them perfect examples of what it means to be Kahila.

The romperi bands embody this diversity. The Pentrak Clan, one of the most widespread and frankly, most annoying of the romperi organizations, draws members from across the Saskan Lands. They include disaffected youth from Fatunik towns seeking adventure, skilled thieves from Mobalbesq looking for better opportunities, sints fleeing persecution, and forest-born Kahila who never knew any

another life. They operate throughout the Outer Lands, and from Pavanarune to Arq, as well as deep into Settarune and Baranuk. They have branches in both of the Kahila territories.

The Pentrak specialize in everything small-scale and easy to pull off: simple gambling schemes, minor protection arrangements, opportunistic thefts, smuggling operations just large enough to be profitable but not large enough to draw serious retaliation. They are respected less for their operations than for their role in Kahila oral tradition. Pentrak love to tell stories about elaborate cons, narrow escapes, and audacious failures. They are told around festival fires with the same attention other cultures give to epic song cycles. The tales serve a purpose. They teach cunning, celebrate resistance to authority, demonstrate that the powerful can be outwitted, and provide a kind of collective instruction manual in how to survive when survival means breaking laws that you never consented to. That the Pentrak are not really all that capable is largely irrelevant.

Bu'ruq and Qu'rub, two young hum who with assistance from Kirill Geckter joined a small bitamin band that specialized in kidnappings after fleeing their Fatunik hometown, represent a common trajectory. Rejected by their communities for minor violations of Fatunik law like singing forbidden songs, they seek out the forest as a place where such things would not matter. Newcomers often find their first home with the Pentrak, participated in their operations, then grew disillusioned with the petty criminal grind, and move on to something more interesting. Such stories are unremarkable among the Kahila, which is precisely what makes them significant. People flow between roles. Nothing is permanent except the commitment to remain free.

More serious operations are conducted by bands like the Khavrokel ('the log-cutters'), known for sabotage against Tagabant installations, or the Arkelun ('the last word'), whose assassination contracts serve both ideological and financial purposes. The Karvashen ('the long wind') are one of the most widely respected Kahila bitamin units, representing the serious paramilitary end of the spectrum. They are trained fighters who conduct raids on Tagabant supply lines and

providing instruction to animal-sint liberation groups. The Karvashen maintain discipline, operational security, and fighting capabilities that match or exceed many Fatunik and Rider Arms units.

But even these serious groups participate in the festival culture. When the Karvashen arrive at a gathering, they don't come as a military unit. They come as a band of successful hunters, offering gifts, sharing stories, dancing, singing, drinking, and participating in the gift-giving competitions that structure the celebrations. A bitamin fighter who has killed Tagabant soldiers might also be an excellent flute player, a devoted parent, a person who weeps openly at the memorial songs sung for the dead.

The festivals serve functions beyond celebration. They are where disputes are mediated, resources redistributed, news shared, bonds arranged, alliances formed, and the Kahila identity renewed. Without formal government, these gatherings are how the culture perpetuates itself. Not through laws, but through repeated participation in practices that embody Kahila values.

The gatherings also serve as cover. Under the guise of seasonal festivals, the romperi and bitamin groups meet to coordinate operations, share intelligence, move supplies, and recruit. A gathering might involve three hundred people celebrating in a forest clearing while in smaller groups around the periphery serious business is conducted. The Watchers and the Rider Arms and anybody else who pays attention to Kahila culture knows this happens but no outsider can effectively intervene in the deep forest. The festivals are mobile, announced through networks outsiders cannot penetrate, and held in locations where any military response would be slow, obvious, and very probably futile.

In recent years, some romperi bands have begun building connections with legitimate trade networks, particularly around Ríkila where the Annaki Intimi operate. The Marn-Vekhar ('deep roots') provide security for Ríkila businesses while maintaining their romperi roots. The Ngarvash ('the hidden path') move rare goods through contacts with Mobali and Nyland sea captains, blurring the line between

smuggling and commerce. The Marn-Kor ('root exchange') supply materials from the forest to merchants in Ríkila, establishing reputations as reliable partners.

This shift toward semi-legitimate operations like the Marn-Kor creates tension within Kahila culture. Some see it as necessary evolution, proof the Kahila can participate in broader economic systems without surrendering autonomy. Others view it as a step toward assimilation, the gradual erosion of the values that have kept them free through centuries of conflict. The debate plays out at informal conclaves, in taverns, around fires. No consensus emerges because the Kahila don't resolve disagreements through voting or decree. They argue, they act according to conscience, and they observe what happens.

What unites the various bands, despite their different approaches and occasional rivalries, is their role in maintaining Kahila cohesion across dispersed populations and occupied territory. The romperi and bitamin move between the provinces carrying messages, goods, and people. They ensure that Kahilakol and Kahilabequa, despite the severed corridor, remain connected. They provide material support that enables communities to survive without depending on systems that would require acknowledgement of an external authority.

Folks living deep in the Kahilakol forests or in an isolated village in occupied Kahilaqor might see a bitamin courier twice a year, a romperi trader only every few months. But those contacts are lifelines, bringing news of kin in Kahilabequa, delivering goods that can't be produced locally, offering assistance if the Tagabant are coming too close. The bands are not separate from Kahila life. They are its circulatory system, moving resources and information through a body that has no central heart.

The diversity of these organizations reflects the diversity of Kahila motivations. Some join for ideological reasons: genuine commitment to resistance, belief in Kahila autonomy, hatred of Fatunik oppression. Others join for practical ones such as the need for protection, the promise of profit, or simply the absence of other options. Some are

running from something. Others are running toward something. The bands accommodate all of this because they must. Purity of motive is a luxury that people who live in contested territory cannot afford.

At the festivals, when the gift-giving reaches its peak and the fires burn high and someone begins singing one of the old songs, the ones about loss and pride and survival, about forests that shelter and rivers that divide, or newer songs about the corridor that was severed and the day it might be whole, at those moments the distinction between romperi, bitamin, farmer, artisan, refugee, and forest-born dissolves. Everyone present is Kahila, participating in practices that are older than the Dominion, remembering together what must not be forgotten, and preparing for whatever comes next.

The Kahila community is complicated and difficult and sometimes dangerous, but community nonetheless. The Kahila folk who chose this life or had it chosen for them, and those who live in the trees and move through the forest and gather when the seasons turn are happy to give away everything they have and to start again as many times as necessary.

The Ruk'taan in Brokily

It was early autumn, in turn 2047 by the common reckoning,

They came by river and road, the Runiks in their midnight blue traveling cloaks, the Mobalbeshqi traders with wagons full of gifts wrapped in undyed cloth, the Nylanders on foot and horseback singing in unison songs that reached Brokily a quarter hour before they did. A Beqawar from High Weir arrived so quietly that no one noticed until she was already standing at the square's edge, watching everything with those steely eyes that miss nothing.

Brokily's central market square had been transformed. The usual stalls were gone, replaced by a series of platforms arranged in concentric

circles around a central fire pit. Timber carved with Kahila forest symbols framed each platform, the spirals representing growth, crossed branches for connection, the empty circle for what was lost and must be found again. Garlands of autumn leaves and river reeds hung between posts. The smell of roasting meat and baking bread and hot root mixed with woodsmoke and the green scent of the Settan.

Taavi opMarn-Kor stood on the innermost platform, uncomfortable in the role of host but determined to see this through. Beside her stood a senior Rider from Bordered whose idea this had been, or at least whose suggestion had catalyzed what the Brokily merchants had already been considering since returning from the previous turn's feast at Wildwind. Behind them, a dozen Kahila elders waited with the stillness of people who survive by knowing when to move and when to be invisible.

"This is madness," whispered Corran opMarn-Vekhar, whose band was responsible for security for the event, watching the square fill with outsiders. "We're exposing ourselves. Making ourselves vulnerable."

"We've been vulnerable for a century," Taavi said quietly. "This is choosing to be visible on our own terms."

The Runiks arrived first at the central platforms, led by an elderly hum woman whose white hair was bound with silver threads. She carried a carved box made of dark wood polished to a mirror shine. The Mobalbeshqi delegation followed, their leader, a spice trader, bore a ceramic jar that smelled of cinnamon and something deeper, earthier. The Nylanders came last in a laughing surge, their gifts already distributed among the crowd: bone whistles, woven bracelets, clay figures no larger than a thumb.

The Beqawar warrior moved through the crowd like water finding channels, appearing suddenly beside Taavi. "Beautiful work," she said, gesturing to the carved platforms. "Your people remember how to make spaces sacred."

"We remember a lot of things," Taavi said, trying not to gawk at the armor worn by the Empafarasi emissary.

The gifting began as the sun touched the western trees. The Kahila went first, as hosts, bringing forward what they did best: carved wooden boxes filled with forest syrup, bundles of medicinal herbs wrapped in bark, and weapons. Yes, weapons. What was that point of a Kahila gift that didn't acknowledge what everyone knew? The knives were displayed and then offered to those who had come unarmed, distributed along with solemn promises that these blades would never taste Runik or Mobali or Nylander blood as these folk has never taken Kahila lives.

The Runiks responded, to no one's surprise, with scrolls and books. The elegant scholar from Byenung opened her dark box to reveal manuscripts on law, philosophy, astronomy. It was knowledge made portable and protected, offered freely. "We brought what we have in abundance," she said. "Questions recorded so they don't die with the questioner."

The Mobalbeshqi handed out spices and seeds, practical gifts that acknowledged Brokily's rebuilt gardens and expanding farms. The representative from the legendary Moballeq Commune opened his ceramic jar to reveal varieties of pepper seeds that would thrive in Kahila soil, along with detailed instructions for cultivation written in three languages. "We brought what grows," he said simply.

The Nylanders, predictably, simply brought chaos and joy. Along with the small presents they had freely handed out to the crowd, they now presented finer instruments, woven goods, and a cask of something that made everyone who tasted it cough and laugh simultaneously and stories they told in song. "We brought what travels," their leader announced. "Like us."

Fatune settled and the moons and stars came out. Fires were lit in pits around the square. Food appeared from Brokily's kitchens and from the visitors' provisions. The feast was assembled from contributions, no single source, everyone feeding everyone else. Musicians from

four cultures attempted to find common rhythms, failed spectacularly, laughed, and tried again until something emerged that was new and belonged to no single tradition.

And then the scholar from Byenung stood and raised her hand.

The square quieted. Not silence. Children still played at the edges, fires still crackled, the river still murmured. But a quality of attention settled over the gathering.

"Among the Bye folks around the Great Lake," said, her voice carrying without strain, "we have a tradition called the whispering rune. It is an old form. Older even than the Night Hall, some say, though we have no proof of that. It begins with an elder speaking a truth so simple it seems empty. Then others offer variations, speaking as different aspects of the world might speak. Each version reveals something that was hidden in the original. Thus we uncover the gift of these words together."

She paused, letting anticipation build.

"We would be honored if this gathering this first ruk'taan, the first Wildwind Festival to be held in Brokily, would participate in this tradition with us. Let us find the truths we might speak together that none of us could speak alone."

Taavi felt her stomach tighten. This was the moment the Rider captain had warned her about. This was what starts to happen when you let the magisters of the Night Hall send their wordsmiths into your house. In a public moment, standing for the first time with representatives of all the great non-Fatunik regions, when words will matter more than gifts, the Kahila would need to demonstrate they are more than warriors and refugees, that their culture had depths worth respecting at the Night Hall.

The Runik sage closed her eyes. When she opened them, her voice had changed. It was softer, more rhythmic. As much as she disdained the Elders of Juuj, Taavi wondered if this is what it is like to attend

one of their sessions around the Deep Pool.

The woman from Byenung intoned, "A stone fell into the lake. The water took its shape. The fish whisper its name. The land forgot it."

She sat. The square held its breath.

The man from Moballeq stood next, his scarred hands clasped before him. The Mobali, especially House Moballeq, now the Moballeq Commune, were the oldest allies of the Magister of the Night Hall. They knew this game very well. "The stone sank true," he said. "Water welcomed it. Life stirred the pot, tasted salt, and said: 'This too shall season.'"

And of the Nylander singers was already standing before the Moballeq trader had finished sitting. "Stone kissed water. Ripple laughed," he shouted. "Life watched and said: 'I'll remember for a while.' Then danced until remembering didn't matter."

Three versions. Three cultures. The Kahila elders had not moved.

Taavi looked at them. Grennak, a veteran of the Karvashen, one of the great living Kahila battle heroes; Sielle, a Khavrokel who, it was rumored anyway, had sent a Tagabant caravan tumbling down a ravine only three days before; Paav, a rabbit-sint said to be a key contact with the Untamed, whose gray fur and clouded eyes marked decades of survival. Warriors. Every single one of them. They sat watching the fire, expressions like stone, faces unreadable.

Grennak stood. Slowly, as if his bones needed convincing. He did not look at the crowd. He looked at the flames.

"Stone fell through fire before it touched water." His voice was rough, underused, more accustomed to forest than crowds. "We saw it burning. Bright. Brief. When it sank, steam rose. Fish called it by its old name, from before the burning. Land pretends to forget. Ash remembers."

He sat.

The square was absolutely silent, even the children.

Sielle stood next. She looked directly at the well-dressed representative from Byenung. "The stone was thrown. Not dropped. Thrown. By hands we saw. Into water where our children swam. It sank. It's still there. We know exactly where it is. The water never settled. The fish avoid that place. But the land—" she smiled without warmth—"the land grows over everything, given time. Even thrown stones."

When she sat, Kahila folk throughout the crowd were quietly sobbing.

Paav stood. The rabbit-sint needed to climb onto the platform's edge to be seen clearly. His voice was surprisingly strong, each word bitten off cleanly.

"Stone fell. We ran. Water splashed. We ran faster. Life paused one heartbeat. tKept running. Stones fall. Always have. Running is how life answers. We remember each stone. Every stone. Shapes. Sounds. Where they fell. Who drowned. Running doesn't mean forgetting."

He hopped down without waiting for response.

The Night Hall spokesperson was standing again, but differently now. Less as a teacher, more as a student. "In the Night Hall," she said slowly, "we argue for generations about whether a truth is discovered or constructed, whether reality precedes language or language shapes reality. I think," she paused. "I think perhaps the Kahila have been answering this question for centuries in ways we were too sophisticated to hear."

"We weren't answering your question," said Grennak from his seat.

"We were living ours."

"Tell us then, what your question is"

Grennak looked at the other elders. A silent exchange occurred. Finally Sielle spoke.

"How do you remain whole when you've been cut in half? How do

you teach children the names of places they may never walk? How do you celebrate life when the dead outnumber the living? How do you give gifts when everything has been taken?" She gestured at the square. "These are not philosophical questions for us. They are morning. They are every morning."

Another member of Mobalbeshqi delegation leader stood, an older woman. "In the fire temples, we say: what burns away was never essential. What remains after burning is the truth of the thing."

"Respectfully," Paav said from his position at the platform's edge, "that's easy to say if you weren't the thing burning."

The woman nodded slowly. "You're right. I apologize."

The Nylander stood up and sang. No words, just a melody that started bright and broke halfway through, reformed, continued in a different key, kept going. As he sang the other Nylands began drumming the ruk'taan, not the whole thing, only a phrase. When he finished, he said simply: "We have songs like that too. Songs that break but then keep going."

Without causing any stir, the Beqawar warrior had moved to stand near the central fire. She spoke without preamble. "In the Mistral Tower we keep records of everything. Rainfall, harvest, births, deaths, court proceedings, trade agreements. We do this because it helps to make us wise. We measure and document the world." She looked around the square. "But there are things that cannot be documented because they are not events. They are absences. Gaps. The shape that water makes when something is removed." She met Sielle's eyes. "Your question is the shape of a corridor. We write around such things in our records, because it impossible to see it directly."

Grennak stood again, feeling bolder. "Then write it now, warrior. Tell your mountain lords to write that the Kahila Lands are three provinces, not two. Write that Kahilaqor is occupied, not annexed. Write that we count the turns from when the connection was severed,

not from when we accepted it, because we have never accepted it. Small thing for you to take up: ink and vellum. It is everything for us. The difference between forgetting and being forgotten."

"Done," said the Beqawar woman immediately. "Our records will reflect the truth. You have my word, which in the Mistral Tower binds my successors." This sent a ripple of excitement and chatter through the crowd. Youngsters from the Pentrak Clan began chanting, "Ríkila! Ríkila!" but were soon hushed by others who were strained to hear every word from the platform.

The woman from Byenung sat down on the platform abruptly, as if her legs had stopped working. "We came here," she said quietly, "thinking to share our traditions with you. To bring you into our conversations, our frameworks, our ways of thinking." She laughed softly. "We are fools sometimes, we scholars. So concerned with questions we forget that folks are living the answers."

The Rider from Borted, spoke for the first time. "We Riders have protocols for everything. How to conduct patrols, how to escort caravans, how to mediate disputes. We even have our own version of the Wildwind Festival in Borted. But we have nothing in our protocols for this," gesturing at the gathering. "How to teach each other by showing our wounds. We are listening to you."

Another wave of nattering rippled through the crowd. A Rider had just publicly acknowledged the Kahila's predicament. What does it mean?...

The fire crackled. Somewhere a child laughed. The river continued its indifferent flow.

Taavi stood, heart hammering, knowing this moment mattered in ways she couldn't fully articulate. " "We have always given away everything we have. Goods, stories, songs," she said "What we've given you tonight at this ruk'taan, at this Brokily version of the great Nylander Wildwind Festival, are our questions. They're what we have most of. They're what we're drowning in. Take them. Carry them back

to the Night Hall, to the fire temples, to Inns of Bordered and to the Mistral Tower, down the long roads and into your record halls. — Take them. Make them your questions too. Maybe questions carried by many are lighter than questions carried alone."

"We'll carry them," the scholar from Byenung said immediately.

"We'll carry them too," echoed the Moballeq's man.

"Already carrying them," the Nylander enthused, "and we'll be singing them on the way home to make sure they don't get lost."

The Beqawar woman just nodded once, sharply, and departed.

The gathering continued until dawn. More food, more songs, more conversations in corners where people from different worlds discovered unexpected common ground, or argued themselves into better understanding. The Nylanders began beating the ruk'taan and everyone danced. The gift-giving extended beyond the formal presentations into spontaneous exchanges throughout the plaza. A Runik scholar trading a book on star navigation for a Kahila carved whistle. A Mobali cook taught a Brokily baker a new way to use honey. In a close embrace with a newfound lover, a Nylander dancer tried on Kahila movement forms and together they created something that was both and neither.

As Fatune rose once more over the Settan, turning the water gold, Grennak stood at the river's edge with the woman from Byenung, who had at long last shared her name. They'd been talking for an hour, or had they been sitting in a comfortable silence contemplating their thoughts. She found it was hard to tell.

"Your stone riddle," Grennak said. "It's good. True. But it assumes the stone fell once, long ago, and now we're remembering it. For us, stones are still falling. Every day. Different stones. Same water."

"Then perhaps," her new friend said carefully, "the riddle needs to continue. Not as one stone remembered, but as many stones falling, many people speaking, the lake never settling, the story never

ending."

"Now you're listening," said Grennak.

Behind them, the square was transforming back into its ordinary self. Platforms were being dismantled, fires banked, visitors preparing for departure or heading to inns for rest first. But something had shifted. The Kahila had been *seen*, not as victims or rebels or criminals, but as a culture with its own wisdom, its own questions, its own ways of answering the fundamental problems of existence.

The First Ruk'taan in Brokily would not end the occupation. It would not reunite the provinces. It would not bring back the dead or heal the old wounds.

But it meant that when the Runiks returned to Byenung, they would carry Kahila questions into the Night Hall's debates. When the Mobalbeshqi sang at their fire temple rituals, they would add to their lore of what it means to burn and keep growing. When the Nylanders filled the road with their songs, they would include verses learned in Brokily, loud and proud. And when the records were updated in vaults at High Weir, they would acknowledge three provinces, not two.

The Kahila, having shown themselves and not been destroyed by the showing, having been met with respect instead of judgment, having discovered that their questions mattered beyond their forests and their grief... the Kahila would remember this too.

The First Ruk'taan, the First Wildwind Festival in Brokily. The beginning of something that had no name yet and might never need one. Just this, the night we spoke together, and were heard.